

A Thin Veiled Night

The 3:10 Shift

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EXT. CAMPFIRE RING - NIGHT

Oak pops. Sparks climb and die over a ring of metal folding chairs.

DESHAWN (17) stands near the heat with a stick in his hand. He points across the ring with it, away from himself.

Across the coals: a MAN IN A GRAY HOODIE feeding split oak. Newspaper under his boot keeps the bark from rolling. A dry cough rises; he covers it with his wrist, and the chair under him creaks. A dented blue thermos stands in the arm's cup holder, there since they lit the wood.

DESHAWN (V.O.)

My name is Deshawn. I was eleven in April of 2020. This is about an old man named Walt Kostelnik who lived alone in a brick ranch off West Tilghman, out toward Cetronia, in a house that still smelled like his wife's hand lotion three weeks after she was gone. It's also about my father, and about a hospital on South Cedar Crest Boulevard where nobody's family was allowed upstairs, and about a little answering machine on a hall table. June had been the believer. Walt was the one who drove her to church and sat in the truck with the radio low. I won't preach. Here's what happened.

CUT TO:

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL AND LIVING ROOM - DAY (APRIL 2020)

The brick ranch sits quiet enough to hear the refrigerator. Late mail waits on the table. A television runs low for company until the news crawls numbers across the bottom, and then Walt turns it dark.

WALT KOSTELNIK (79) keeps himself busy with jobs that do not need doing. Walt's hands still carry the shape they took from thirty-four years on the Macungie Mack line. He wears his work jacket with his name stitched in red over the pocket. When he reaches under the bed for his shoes he still finds June's slippers there. Her Bible stays on the nightstand beside the lamp, and the blue church coat she wore on Sundays hangs in the closet exactly where she left it.

On the mantel sits Theresa's nursing-school photo in whites, and a balsa Mack cab Walt built on weekends, mirrors the size of apple seeds. On the fridge: a chrome bulldog magnet from a plant Christmas party.

EXT. WALT'S RANCH / FRONT STEP - DAY

THERESA KOSTELNIK stands in the driveway in scrubs and a mask. She talks to Walt through the storm door and will not step into his kitchen with the ward on her clothes.

She leaves a paper bag of masks with a bottle of hand gel on the step. Taped to the bag, in the print she learned from June: USE THESE, DAD.

Walt stows the gel under the sink.

INT. ACME ON TILGHMAN - DAY

Walt wears a mask down the early aisles and hates the way his glasses fogged.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - DAY

Walt comes in from the curb with groceries. The answering machine light blinks once.

He sets the bag down and presses play with his thumb. Soft grit of tape on the heads. Then JUNE'S VOICE fills the hall.

JUNE (ON TAPE)

Walt, I put the good scissors back
in the junk drawer. Stop looking
in the sewing box. I love you.

The counter shows 012. Walt knows that recording; she left
it three years ago. The phone never rang for this one.

He presses stop. He holds rewind until the counter rolls to
000. He takes his hand off the lid.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Walt pulls open the junk drawer. Under masking tape and
leftover stamps: the good scissors. He closes the drawer
with his hip.

Outside, June's bird feeder hangs empty and knocks the
porch post whenever the wind moves. Walt fills a glass at
the sink and stays there listening to that knock before he
turns away.

INT. THERESA'S CAR / STAFF LOT - NIGHT

Theresa sits in the dark lot, engine killed, windows
cracked for air. Mask straps have left red marks on her
cheekbones. A helicopter works the valley somewhere above.
Through the phone comes the thin sound of her breath.

THERESA
Dad. You eating?

WALT (ON PHONE)
I heated the stew. The one in the
blue lid.

THERESA
Good. Listen. I have a patient.
Marcus. Forty-one. On a vent. His
boy is eleven. The boy's name is
Deshawn. The grandmother brings
him to the lot and they sit in a
gray Honda and wait for me to call
them on the iPad so they can see
his face. I'm telling you because
I can't tell him what I want to

tell him, and I have to tell
somebody.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Walt sits. June's strawberry placemat is still under his elbow.

WALT
Is he going to make it?

THERESA (ON PHONE)
I don't know. I'm doing the work.
That's what I know.

She hangs up. Walt washes the stew bowl and racks it. Stove clock: 8:40. In the hall the machine light stays dark. He leaves the buttons alone.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / KITCHEN - MORNING

Walt runs the old percolator. The drip machine's carafe cracked years ago and he never bought another.

June's Bible opens on the counter. Soft pencil fills the margins. Beside Luke 22:32, verse words left unwritten, her block print reads: 3:10, for Walt.

Walt's thumb traces the graphite. Hand-cream oil stains the bottom corner. He rests his palm on the cover until the percolator hisses. He drinks the coffee black at the sink and watches the empty street.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - DAY

At noon the machine blinks again. Walt presses play. The tape hisses, and the counter jumps to 047. June comes through on a different tape, the picnic she wanted him at.

JUNE (ON TAPE)
You don't have to believe every
word they say in there. You only
have to keep showing up for the

people. That's half of it, Walt.
Showing up.

Walt lets it finish. He keeps his finger on rewind until the counter hits 000 and the motor clicks off. Then he puts the lid down.

EXT. CEDAR CREST HOSPITAL PARKING LOT - AFTERNOON

Walt drives Cedar Crest in the Buick, windows sealed, radio off. Half the cars don't look like staff cars. Engines off. People wait on phone calls. A rosary hangs from a minivan mirror. A man in a pickup rests his forehead on the wheel.

Walt spots Theresa's blue Corolla under a light pole and loads the trunk: milk, bread, sharp cheddar, apples if they look decent. He stands with his keys and does not climb back in right away.

Two rows over, a gray Honda. DESHAWN (11) has a homework folder on his knees. RUTH, his grandmother, holds a phone to her ear behind the wheel.

Walt lifts his hand once when he catches the boy looking. Not quite a wave. Then he drives home.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

Stove clock shows 3:05. Walt sits at the table with June's Bible shut under his palm.

At 3:10 he does not pray.

The refrigerator hums. A truck rolls past on Tilghman. A floorboard ticks as it cools. He stays until 3:20, then stands and washes a spoon that is already clean, because his hands want work.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - DAY

Friday. Walt comes in from the walk with the broom still in one hand. The machine light blinks. He hits play. The tape

hisses again, and the counter lands on 091. June is softer this time, calling from her sister's place in Bethlehem.

JUNE (ON TAPE)

I know you're angry at God about your back. Be angry. Just don't stop listening. He can take a man's temper. I have seen it.

Walt leans the broom on the wall. He rewinds to 000 and sets his hands on the hall-table edge until his shoulders drop. Then he makes a grilled cheese over the sink so crumbs stay off June's placemat.

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Theresa calls from inside. Machine sounds behind her. A cart wheel squeaks.

THERESA

Marcus had a rough afternoon. Deshawn asked me if his dad could hear him through the tube. I told him yes. I don't know if that's true. I told him yes anyway.

WALT (ON PHONE)

You did right.

THERESA

Dad. Do you ever...

She stops. She swallows.

THERESA (CONT'D)

Never mind. I have to go. The iPad is ringing.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - NIGHT

Walt lifts the shoe box beside the machine. Tiny labels in June's print: picnic, scissors, Bethlehem, Theresa grad, Christmas 12. At the bottom one cassette carries no label. He leaves it there and closes the box.

INT. GRAY HONDA / CEDAR CREST LOT - DAY

Deshawn has a library shark book open on his knees. Ruth keeps a rosary on her wrist and peanut-butter crackers in the door pocket. He reads the chapters out loud to the dashboard until his throat dries and she passes the water jug. Crumbs fall into the seat; she digs them out with two fingers and eats them. Waste is a sin in her house.

EXT. CEDAR CREST HOSPITAL PARKING LOT - SATURDAY AFTERNOON

Walt parks and sets a coffee thermos and two paper cups on Theresa's roof under the wiper. The gray Honda is back. Deshawn rides the back seat with the shark book. Ruth sleeps with her mouth open and the rosary still on her wrist.

Walt stays put with the door cracked. He watches hospital glass that will not tell him a thing.

The dashboard clock reads ten after three. He steps out between the Buick and a painted asphalt line. His cap comes off into both of his hands.

Deshawn sees him through the Honda glass.

Walt drops his chin. Out loud, for the first time he can remember, he prays. His voice is rough and low.

WALT

I don't know how this works. June said you listen. If you're listening, this isn't for me. This is for a man named Marcus on a ventilator upstairs. His boy is in that Honda. Let him live. Let the boy keep his father. I don't have the words past that.

INT. BUICK / CEDAR CREST BOULEVARD - MOVING

Walt puts his cap back on and takes the Buick back along Cedar Crest, hands locked at ten and two. Ahead, a dump truck taps brakes at Tilghman; Walt taps his. The thermos

rolls once on the passenger mat and stops against his work boot.

INT. CEDAR CREST ICU / MARCUS'S BAY - SAME TIME

Theresa stands at MARCUS's bed, gloved hand on the rail. She does not know her father is in the lot. Thirty seconds between tasks. She uses them the way June taught her as a girl: head down, mouth moving behind the mask.

THERESA

Lord, hold Marcus. Hold Deshawn.
Hold my dad sitting in that house.
Amen.

Then she is back on lines and numbers.

Theresa checks the charge nurse's clock when she finishes. Walt checks the dashboard when he turns the key. Both clocks read 3:10.

DESHAWN (V.O.)

And that's as far as the fact goes.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - LATER

Walt comes home to a blinking light.

He sets his keys in the dish and lifts the lid before he touches any button. The cassette in the well carries no label.

He checks the shoe box. Friday's blank cassette is gone from the bottom, and bare cardboard shows where it sat. He closes the box.

Walt presses play. The counter climbs to 003. The hiss stretches longer than the old messages, with a thin room sound riding under it, and then June comes through clear, closer to the mic than on the older tapes.

JUNE (ON TAPE)

Theresa's here. She can't hear me
talk past the machine. That's all

right. Walt. Listen to me. If it comes down to it, let him pray for somebody else first. Do you hear me. Somebody else first. Then the rest will follow. I love you. I'm not afraid.

The tape clicks. Counter at 028. The machine's little voice speaks the stamp: Wednesday, 3:10 a.m.

Walt stops without rewinding. He walks to the kitchen and dials Theresa.

INT. HOSPITAL SUPPLY CLOSET - CONTINUOUS

She picks up on the second ring from a supply closet she ducks into when the ward gets too loud inside her head.

THERESA

Dad.

WALT (ON PHONE)

The night your mother died. You were in the room.

THERESA

Yes.

WALT (ON PHONE)

What did you hear.

A pager fires somewhere behind her. She stays quiet a long stretch.

THERESA

The ventilator. That's what I heard. The ventilator, and the alarms we silenced, and a chaplain at the door who couldn't come in past the line. She didn't talk, Dad. Not that I could hear. I held her hand through a glove and I watched the numbers and I told her about you sitting at home because they wouldn't let you up. That's what I heard.

WALT (ON PHONE)

All right.

THERESA

Why.

WALT (ON PHONE)

I'll tell you later. Go back to work.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - CONTINUOUS

Walt hangs up and returns to the hall.

DESHAWN (V.O.)

Those are the two facts I have for you. I'm not going to put a bridge between them.

He holds rewind to 000, pops the cassette, and pencils JUNE FINAL on the tiny label strip. He sets it in the shoe box above the rest.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / KITCHEN - SUNDAY

Oatmeal on the stove. Walt calls Theresa. Marcus's numbers sit a little better.

At 3:10 he sits at the table again. This time he prays out loud for Marcus, for Theresa's hands, for the eleven-year-old waiting in that Honda with his shark library book. His eyes stay open; closing them still strikes him as foolish. Afterward he dries the pot and hangs the towel on the oven door.

He lifts the free funeral-home calendar off its nail, covered bridge for April. Carpenter's pencil from the junk drawer. He writes 3:10 in every square left in the month, block letters heavy enough to dent the next page. Hung crooked. He leaves it crooked.

INT. THERESA'S CAR - WEDNESDAY - DAY

Theresa calls from the car. Her mask hangs off one ear. Twelve hours have cracked her voice.

THERESA

They are going to try to wean
Marcus tomorrow. If it goes well,
Deshawn might hear his dad's voice
by the weekend. Dad. What did you
do.

WALT (ON PHONE)

I bought cheddar.

THERESA

That isn't what I asked.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / HALL - CONTINUOUS

Walt looks at the dark machine light. His hand rests on the plastic lid, then comes off it.

WALT

I asked for help for your patient.
In the lot. That's all.

Theresa makes a sound that's half a laugh and half the other thing people do when they've been holding a ward up with their shoulders. She has to pull her own groceries from the trunk before the milk turns. She hangs up.

EXT. CEDAR CREST HOSPITAL PARKING LOT - SATURDAY

Tube out. Marcus's voice is wrecked, but it is his. Ruth puts her forehead on the Honda wheel and cries.

Theresa in scrubs stays six feet from their bumper and tells them they can wave at a third-floor window if they want. They do, waving at glass that only reflects.

Walt is back with his thermos. Theresa walks him over at a distance.

THERESA

Deshawn, this is my dad. He's been
praying for your dad.

Walt looks at Deshawn like a job he means to finish.

WALT
You like sharks.

DESHAWN
Yes, sir.

WALT
Great whites are bullies. I always
liked the hammerheads. They mind
their business.

DESHAWN (V.O.)
That's the first thing Walt
Kostelnik ever said to me.

EXT. RUTH'S YARD / FOURTH STREET - DAY (MAY / JUNE)

Marcus comes home on a walker with exercise sheets and a
temper that burns quick.

Walt leaves a casserole on the porch, rings the bell, and
is back in the car before the door opens.

Later he brings a second folding chair and sits while
Marcus walks the maple and back. The yard on Fourth Street
is small, and the fence leans, and Ruth has tomatoes
growing in buckets along the sunny side. Walt pinches a
sucker off without asking and drops it in the grass. Ruth
watches from the kitchen window and stays inside.

Marcus hates the walker. Walt offers no advice. He drinks
coffee from the dented blue thermos while a robin yells at
a squirrel. When the lap is done:

WALT
Again.

EXT. WALT'S RANCH / BACK STEP - DAY (ONE YEAR LATER)

DESHAWN (12) shares the back step with Walt and two lemonades. A neighbor kid rides past with a playing card in the spokes.

DESHAWN

What was on that last tape.

WALT

June said if it comes down to it,
let him pray for somebody else
first. Theresa heard the
ventilator. Those are the two
facts. I took the shift. That's
the part that belongs to me.

He drinks his lemonade and watches the kid on the bike.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / BEDROOM - NIGHT (LAST WINTER)

Walt dies in his own bed. Theresa holds his hand. No ventilator in the room.

INT. WALT'S RANCH / BEDROOM - DAY

They are cleaning out the ranch. June's Bible lies open to the Luke page on the nightstand. Under her old note, Walt's thicker pencil added one line:

3:10. For whoever needs it.

EXT. CAMPFIRE RING - NIGHT

Oak pops. Sparks rise.

Deshawn stands where he started. Across the ring the man in the gray hoodie feeds another split into the coals. His wrist covers the cough. Cool metal ticks from the thermos in the cup holder.

DESHAWN (V.O.)

That man is my dad. Marcus lived.
Walt took the three-ten shift so a
boy in a Honda could keep hearing
a voice. Walt isn't at this fire

tonight. I still pray at three-ten
when I remember. On the days I
remember, I don't pray for myself
first. I learned that from an old
Mack hand who kept showing up. And
that's the end of what I came to
tell you.

Marcus feeds the oak. The thermos ticks.

FADE OUT.